WEST ASIA, ENERGY SECURITY AND CONNECTIVITY

CENTRAL QUESTION AND THE → TWO VARIABLES ANSWERS KEEP → ENERGY TRILEMMA AS THE → ISRAEL TRACK: DEPTH ACROSS → GULF ARCHITECTURE WITH DATES → TRADE INSTRUMENTS AND THEIR

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

● PRIMARY CORE FLOW ○ SUBORDINATE EXTRA ◆ APPROVAL / REVIEW

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • active generation g1 • explicit approval of this exact generation is required • all prior artifacts unchanged

00 STAGE 00 — CENTRAL QUESTION AND THE THREE PARALLEL TRACKS

CENTRAL QUESTION AND THE THREE PARALLEL TRACKS · HOW DOES ONE REGION CARRY ENERGY, PEOPLE AND CORRIDORS · ROOT CONDITION · CRUDE-OIL IMPORT DEPENDENCE OF 88.2% IN FY2024-25 · ABOUT 88.7% PROVISIONAL IN FY2025-26; SIKRI'S BOOK PERIOD · APPROXIMATELY 70% · TRACK 1 · GULF AND ARAB WORLD

INTEREST / DOCTRINE

- CENTRAL QUESTION → how does one region carry energy, people and corridors at once?
- ROOT CONDITION → crude-oil import dependence of 88.2% in FY2024-25
- about 88.7% provisional in FY2025-26; Sikri's book period: approximately 70%

DIPLOMATIC MECHANISM

- TRACK 1 → GULF and ARAB WORLD: energy and diaspora
- TRACK 2 → ISRAEL: technology, defence, agriculture, innovation
- TRACK 3 → IRAN: energy history and Chabahar connectivity

CONSTRAINT / TRADE-OFF

- DOCTRINE → Look West, named by Tharoor as a parallel to Look East
- RULE → parallel and non-exclusive tracks, never a sequence of choices

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: RULE → parallel and non-exclusive tracks, never a sequence of choices.

01 STAGE 01 — TWO VARIABLES ANSWERS KEEP MERGING

TWO VARIABLES ANSWERS KEEP MERGING · WIDENING THE SET OF SUPPLIERS AND EQUITY SOURCES · US SHARE 4.6% · 8.1%; UAE SHARE 9.4% → 11.1%, APRIL-NOVEMBER FY26 · ALSO ROSE · EGYPT, NIGERIA, LIBYA · RUSSIA, SAUDI ARABIA, IRAQ, VENEZUELA

ACTOR / INTEREST	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	STATUS TRAP / LIMIT
DIVERSIFICATION → widening the set of suppliers and equity sources	DECLINED: Russia, Saudi Arabia, Iraq, Venezuela	VERDICT → diversification of sources, expressly not reduction of dependence
EVIDENCE: US share 4.6% → 8.1%; UAE share 9.4% → 11.1%, April-November FY26	DEPENDENCE REDUCTION → lowering the share of consumption that must be imported	BRAKE → refineries devised for the quality of crude that Iran supplies
ALSO ROSE: Egypt, Nigeria, Libya	EVIDENCE: aggregate dependence remained very high across the same period	

ACTOR / INTEREST

- DIVERSIFICATION → widening the set of suppliers and equity sources
- EVIDENCE: US share 4.6% → 8.1%; UAE share 9.4% → 11.1%, April-November FY26
- ALSO ROSE: Egypt, Nigeria, Libya

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

- DECLINED: Russia, Saudi Arabia, Iraq, Venezuela
- DEPENDENCE REDUCTION → lowering the share of consumption that must be imported
- EVIDENCE: aggregate dependence remained very high across the same period

STATUS TRAP / LIMIT

- VERDICT → diversification of sources, expressly not reduction of dependence
- BRAKE → refineries devised for the quality of crude that Iran supplies

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: VERDICT → diversification of sources, expressly not reduction of dependence.

02 STAGE 02 — ENERGY TRILEMMA AS THE EVALUATIVE FRAME

ENERGY TRILEMMA AS THE EVALUATIVE FRAME · SUSTAINABILITY SUPPLY · PRICE EXPOSURE AND · TRANSITION PRESSURE AND RELIABILITY · IMPORT-BILL BURDEN · LONG-HORIZON SUBSTITUTION · A SECURITY-ONLY FRAME HIDES TRADE-OFFS BETWEEN THESE THREE LIMBS · DIVERSIFICATION SERVES SECURITY; IT DOES NOT SETTLE AFFORDABILITY

ACTOR / INTEREST	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	STATUS TRAP / LIMIT
SUSTAINABILITY supply	import-bill burden	APPLIED → diversification serves security; it does not settle affordability
price exposure and	long-horizon substitution	APPLIED → transition pressure reshapes what security will mean over time
transition pressure and reliability	TENSION → a security-only frame hides trade-offs between these three limbs	RULE → evaluate the portfolio on all three axes, not on supply alone

ACTOR / INTEREST

- SUSTAINABILITY supply
- price exposure and
- transition pressure and reliability

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

- import-bill burden
- long-horizon substitution
- TENSION → a security-only frame hides trade-offs between these three limbs

STATUS TRAP / LIMIT

- APPLIED → diversification serves security; it does not settle affordability
- APPLIED → transition pressure reshapes what security will mean over time
- RULE → evaluate the portfolio on all three axes, not on supply alone

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: RULE → evaluate the portfolio on all three axes, not on supply alone.

03 STAGE 03 — ISRAEL TRACK: DEPTH ACROSS DISTINCT DOMAINS

ISRAEL TRACK · DEPTH ACROSS DISTINCT DOMAINS · FULL DIPLOMATIC RELATIONS ESTABLISHED · JULY 2017 · FIRST VISIT BY AN INDIAN PRIME MINISTER TO ISRAEL · PROCUREMENT, COUNTER-TERRORISM, CO-DEVELOPMENT; BARAK-8 · INDO-ISRAEL AGRICULTURAL PROJECT CENTRES OF EXCELLENCE · INDUSTRIAL R&D AND TECHNOLOGICAL INNOVATION FUND, 2017

1992 → full diplomatic relations established

JULY 2017 → first visit by an Indian Prime Minister to Israel → DEFENCE: procurement, counter-terrorism, co-development; Barak-8 → AGRICULTURE: Indo-Israel Agricultural Project Centres of Excellence

INTEREST / DOCTRINE

- 1992 → full diplomatic relations established
- JULY 2017 → first visit by an Indian Prime Minister to Israel
- DEFENCE: procurement, counter-terrorism, co-development; Barak-8

DIPLOMATIC MECHANISM

- AGRICULTURE: Indo-Israel Agricultural Project Centres of Excellence
- INNOVATION: Industrial R&D and Technological Innovation Fund, 2017
- MINILATERAL: I2U2 food, water, energy and technology cooperation

CONSTRAINT / TRADE-OFF

- LIMITS → transfer depth; cost, extension and scaling, regional conflict

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: LIMITS → transfer depth, cost, extension and scaling, regional conflict.

04 STAGE 04 — GULF ARCHITECTURE WITH DATES AND FORUMS

GULF ARCHITECTURE WITH DATES AND FORUMS · 9 SEPTEMBER 2024, RIYADH · INDIA-GCC JOINT ACTION PLAN 2024-2028, ADOPTED AT THE FIRST · 22 APRIL 2025, JEDDAH · SECOND INDIA-SAUDI ARABIA STRATEGIC PARTNERSHIP COUNCIL · 18 FEBRUARY 2025 · INDIA-QATAR AGREEMENT ON A BILATERAL STRATEGIC PARTNERSHIP · 25 JANUARY 2017

ACTOR / INTEREST	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	STATUS TRAP / LIMIT
9 SEPTEMBER 2024, RIYADH → India-GCC Joint Action Plan 2024-2028, adopted at the first Joint Ministerial Meeting for Strategic Dialogue	18 FEBRUARY 2025 → India-Qatar Agreement on a Bilateral Strategic Partnership	RULE → name the dated instrument and its forum, never an undated partnership
22 APRIL 2025, JEDDAH → second India-Saudi Arabia Strategic Partnership Council	25 JANUARY 2017 → India-UAE Comprehensive Strategic Partnership	9 SEPTEMBER 2024, RIYADH → India-GCC Joint Action Plan 2024-2028, adopted at the first Joint Ministerial Meeting for Strategic Dialogue

ACTOR / INTEREST

- 9 SEPTEMBER 2024, RIYADH → India-GCC Joint Action Plan 2024-2028, adopted at the first Joint Ministerial Meeting for Strategic Dialogue
- 22 APRIL 2025, JEDDAH → second India-Saudi Arabia Strategic Partnership Council

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

- 18 FEBRUARY 2025 → India-Qatar Agreement on a Bilateral Strategic Partnership
- 25 JANUARY 2017 → India-UAE Comprehensive Strategic Partnership

STATUS TRAP / LIMIT

- RULE → name the dated instrument and its forum, never an undated partnership
- 9 SEPTEMBER 2024, RIYADH → India-GCC Joint Action Plan 2024-2028, adopted at the first Joint Ministerial Meeting for Strategic Dialogue

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: RULE → name the dated instrument and its forum, never an undated partnership.

05 STAGE 05 — TRADE INSTRUMENTS AND THEIR FORCE STATUS

TRADE INSTRUMENTS AND THEIR FORCE STATUS · INDIA-UAE CEPA · IN FORCE SINCE 1 MAY 2022 REPORTED BILATERAL TRADE · INDIA-OMAN CEPA · SIGNED ON 18 DECEMBER 2025 ENTRY INTO FORCE REQUIRES · TARIFF AND TRADE-VOLUME MECHANICS BELONG TO THE ECONOMY OWNER · IR KEEPS · THE STRATEGIC-PARTNERSHIP SIGNIFICANCE OF EACH INSTRUMENT

ACTOR / INTEREST	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	STATUS TRAP / LIMIT
INDIA-UAE CEPA → IN FORCE since 1 May 2022 reported bilateral trade approximately USD 100 billion in FY2024-25	BOUNDARY → tariff and trade-volume mechanics belong to the Economy owner	INDIA-UAE CEPA → IN FORCE since 1 May 2022 reported bilateral trade approximately USD 100 billion in FY2024-25
INDIA-OMAN CEPA → SIGNED on 18 December 2025 entry into force requires separate verification	IR KEEPS → the strategic-partnership significance of each instrument	INDIA-OMAN CEPA → SIGNED on 18 December 2025 entry into force requires separate verification

ACTOR / INTEREST

- INDIA-UAE CEPA → IN FORCE since 1 May 2022 reported bilateral trade approximately USD 100 billion in FY2024-25
- INDIA-OMAN CEPA → SIGNED on 18 December 2025 entry into force requires separate verification

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

- BOUNDARY → tariff and trade-volume mechanics belong to the Economy owner
- IR KEEPS → the strategic-partnership significance of each instrument

STATUS TRAP / LIMIT

- INDIA-UAE CEPA → IN FORCE since 1 May 2022 reported bilateral trade approximately USD 100 billion in FY2024-25
- INDIA-OMAN CEPA → SIGNED on 18 December 2025 entry into force requires separate verification

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: IR KEEPS → the strategic-partnership significance of each instrument.

06 STAGE 06 — CORRIDOR DIPLOMACY AGAINST CORRIDOR INFRASTRUCTURE

CORRIDOR DIPLOMACY AGAINST CORRIDOR INFRASTRUCTURE · 9 SEPTEMBER 2023, NEW DELHI · IMEC MEMORANDUM SIGNED BY EIGHT PARTIES · INDIA, US, SAUDI ARABIA, UAE, EU, FRANCE, GERMANY, ITALY · 24 JUNE 2024 · MEA INDIA-UAE READOUT REFERS TO COMMENCEMENT OF WORK · NO COMPLETED CONSTRUCTION OR OPERATING SEGMENT OFFICIALLY ESTABLISHED · CONNECTIVITY DIPLOMACY CREATES MOMENTUM, NOT DELIVERED INFRASTRUCTURE

9 SEPTEMBER 2023, NEW DELHI — IMEC memorandum signed by eight parties → India, US, Saudi Arabia, UAE, EU, France, Germany, Italy → 24 JUNE 2024: MEA India-UAE readout refers to commencement of work → STATUS: no completed construction or operating segment officially established → CONSEQUENCE → connectivity diplomacy creates momentum, not delivered infrastructure

INTEREST / DOCTRINE

- 9 SEPTEMBER 2023, NEW DELHI → IMEC memorandum signed by eight parties
- India, US, Saudi Arabia, UAE, EU, France, Germany, Italy

DIPLOMATIC MECHANISM

- 24 JUNE 2024: MEA India-UAE readout refers to commencement of work
- STATUS: no completed construction or operating segment officially established

CONSTRAINT / TRADE-OFF

- CONSEQUENCE → connectivity diplomacy creates momentum, not delivered infrastructure
- STRESS TEST → regional conflict raises political, security and route-risk costs

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: STRESS TEST → regional conflict raises political, security and route-risk costs.

07 STAGE 07 — IRAN TRACK: INSTRUMENT, WITHDRAWAL AND DISPUTED STATUS

IRAN TRACK · INSTRUMENT, WITHDRAWAL AND DISPUTED STATUS · 14 JULY 2015 · JOINT COMPREHENSIVE PLAN OF ACTION CONCLUDED, IRAN WITH E3/EU+3 · ENDORSED BY UN SECURITY COUNCIL RESOLUTION 2231 · 8 MAY 2018 · UNITED STATES ANNOUNCES WITHDRAWAL; SANCTIONS RESTORED IN STAGES · MAY 2019

14 JULY 2015 — Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action concluded, Iran with E3/EU+3 → endorsed by UN Security Council resolution 2231 → 8 MAY 2018 — United States announces withdrawal; sanctions restored in stages → MAY 2019 — Significant Reduction Exceptions end; India ceases Iranian crude purchases → 13 MAY 2024 — ten-year Chabahar contract signed

DATED OFFICIAL INSTRUMENT

- 14 JULY 2015 — Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action concluded, Iran with E3/EU+3
- endorsed by UN Security Council resolution 2231
- 8 MAY 2018 — United States announces withdrawal; sanctions restored in stages

EVIDENTIARY LEVEL IT REACHES

- MAY 2019 — Significant Reduction Exceptions end; India ceases Iranian crude purchases
- 13 MAY 2024 — ten-year Chabahar contract signed
- 29 SEPTEMBER 2025 — the 2018 Chabahar exception revoked with effect from this date

STATUS / CLAIM LIMIT

- 2025 — after the E3 snapback action the status of restored UN measures is disputed by Iran, Russia and China
- do not call the Plan normally functioning

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: 2025 → after the E3 snapback action the status of restored UN measures is disputed by Iran, Russia and China; do not call the Plan normally functioning.

08 STAGE 08 — COMPOUNDING RISK AT ONE CHOKEPOINT

COMPOUNDING RISK AT ONE CHOKEPOINT · STRAIT OF HORMUZ · NARROW OUTLET FROM THE PERSIAN GULF TO THE GULF · FREIGHT, INSURANCE AND SUPPLY INSECURITY TRANSMIT IMMEDIATELY · PHYSICAL SAFETY OF A VERY LARGE EXPATRIATE POPULATION IS · CORRIDOR AND PROJECT VIABILITY IS EXPOSED AT THE SAME · DIVERSIFICATION DOES NOT REMOVE COMMON-ROUTE EXPOSURE · RESERVES AND ALTERNATIVE ENERGY REDUCE BUT DO NOT REMOVE

STRAIT OF HORMUZ — narrow outlet from the Persian Gulf to the Gulf of Oman → ENERGY: freight, insurance and supply insecurity transmit immediately → DIASPORA: physical safety of a very large expatriate population is exposed → CONNECTIVITY: corridor and project viability is exposed at the same moment → LIMIT — diversification does not remove common-route exposure

INTEREST / DOCTRINE

- STRAIT OF HORMUZ — narrow outlet from the Persian Gulf to the Gulf of Oman
- ENERGY: freight, insurance and supply insecurity transmit immediately
- DIASPORA: physical safety of a very large expatriate population is exposed

DIPLOMATIC MECHANISM

- CONNECTIVITY: corridor and project viability is exposed at the same moment
- LIMIT — diversification does not remove common-route exposure
- LIMIT → reserves and alternative energy reduce but do not remove the risk

CONSTRAINT / TRADE-OFF

- DISTINCTIVE → compounding rather than isolated risk, unlike most partner regions

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: DISTINCTIVE → compounding rather than isolated risk, unlike most partner regions.

09 STAGE 09 — DIASPORA EXPOSURE PRICED WITH DATED EVIDENCE

DIASPORA EXPOSURE PRICED WITH DATED EVIDENCE · A DIASPORA OF 5 MILLION IN THE GULF, PERIOD-SPECIFIC · THE ARAB WORLD IS HOME TO NEARLY 6 MILLION · MEA TABLE, JANUARY 2026 · UAE 4,344,008 · SAUDI ARABIA 2,750,551 · POPULATION-STOCK ESTIMATES, NOT CITIZENSHIP OR OCI COUNTS · 27 JUNE 2025

ACTOR / INTEREST	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	STATUS TRAP / LIMIT
SIKRI → a diaspora of 5 million in the Gulf, period-specific	Saudi Arabia 2,750,551	3,597 from Iran and 818 from Israel
THAROOR → the Arab world is home to nearly 6 million Indians, period-specific	STATUS → population-stock estimates, not citizenship or OCI counts	BOUNDARY → relief logistics to Disaster Management; consular diplomacy here and topic 09
MEA TABLE, JANUARY 2026 → UAE 4,344,008	27 JUNE 2025 → Operation Sindhu evacuated 4,415 nationals	

ACTOR / INTEREST

- SIKRI → a diaspora of 5 million in the Gulf, period-specific
- THAROOR → the Arab world is home to nearly 6 million Indians, period-specific
- MEA TABLE, JANUARY 2026 → UAE 4,344,008

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

- Saudi Arabia 2,750,551
- STATUS → population-stock estimates, not citizenship or OCI counts
- 27 JUNE 2025 → Operation Sindhu evacuated 4,415 nationals

STATUS TRAP / LIMIT

- 3,597 from Iran and 818 from Israel
- BOUNDARY → relief logistics to Disaster Management; consular diplomacy here and topic 09

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: BOUNDARY → relief logistics to Disaster Management; consular diplomacy here and topic 09.

10 STAGE 10 — BALANCING WITHOUT CONTRADICTION

BALANCING WITHOUT CONTRADICTION · DEEPENING ISRAEL TIES COULD BE READ AS A SLIGHT · INDIA VALUES ISRAEL TIES BUT NOT AT THE EXPENSE · A TWO-STATE POSITION COULD BE READ AS ABANDONING ISRAEL · RECOGNITION OF THE STATE OF PALESTINE IN 1988 RUNS · THE OCTOBER 2023 CONFLICT TESTS BOTH LIMBS AT ONCE · CONDEMN TERRORISM, SEEK HUMANITARIAN PROTECTION, HOSTAGE RELEASE, DIALOGUE · ACTIVE BALANCING SUSTAINED BY CONTINUOUS EFFORT, NOT A SINGLE

INTEREST / DOCTRINE

- PROBLEM → deepening Israel ties could be read as a slight by Arab partners
- RESPONSE: India values Israel ties but not at the expense of Arab and Muslim friendships
- PROBLEM → a two-state position could be read as abandoning Israel cooperation

DIPLOMATIC MECHANISM

- RESPONSE: recognition of the State of Palestine in 1988 runs alongside full relations
- PROBLEM → the October 2023 conflict tests both limbs at once
- RESPONSE: condemn terrorism, seek humanitarian protection, hostage release, dialogue

CONSTRAINT / TRADE-OFF

- VERDICT → active balancing sustained by continuous effort; not a single declaration

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: VERDICT → active balancing sustained by continuous effort, not a single declaration.

11 STAGE 11 — ANSWER SPINE FOR A WEST ASIA DEMAND

ANSWER SPINE FOR A WEST ASIA DEMAND · STATE THE DEPENDENCE BASELINE WITH ITS EXACT FINANCIAL YEAR · ENERGY, DIASPORA, TECHNOLOGY AND CONNECTIVITY, EACH WITH ONE DATED · PRICE CHOKEPOINT EXPOSURE, SANCTIONS TRANSMISSION AND UNVERIFIED MINILATERAL ACTIVITY · GIVE A TRILEMMA VERDICT ON A NON-EXCLUSIVE PORTFOLIO, PREDICTING

OPEN → state the dependence baseline with its exact financial year and basis → BUILD → energy, diaspora, technology and connectivity, each with one dated instrument → TEST → price chokepoint exposure, sanctions transmission and unverified minilateral activity → CLOSE → give a trilemma verdict on a non-exclusive portfolio, predicting no price or outcome

INTEREST / DOCTRINE

- OPEN → state the dependence baseline with its exact financial year and basis
- BUILD → energy, diaspora, technology and connectivity, each with one dated instrument

DIPLOMATIC MECHANISM

- TEST → price chokepoint exposure, sanctions transmission and unverified minilateral activity
- CLOSE → give a trilemma verdict on a non-exclusive portfolio, predicting no price or outcome

CONSTRAINT / TRADE-OFF

- OPEN → state the dependence baseline with its exact financial year and basis
- BUILD → energy, diaspora, technology and connectivity, each with one dated instrument

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CLOSE → give a trilemma verdict on a non-exclusive portfolio, predicting no price or outcome.

E EXTRA — SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT · INDIA-GCC JOINT ACTION PLAN (2024-2028) · ADOPTED AT THE FIRST INDIA-GCC · BILATERAL STRATEGIC ARCHITECTURE · THE INDIA-SAUDI STRATEGIC PARTNERSHIP · UAE-INDIA CEPA (IN FORCE 1 MAY 2022) · A BILATERAL TRADE-AGREEMENT · I2U2 (INDIA-ISRAEL-UAE-US)

OPTIONAL DOCTRINE AND INSTRUMENT DEPTH

- India-GCC Joint Action Plan (2024-2028): adopted at the first India-GCC
- Bilateral strategic architecture: the India-Saudi Strategic Partnership
- CAUTION: UAE-India CEPA (in force 1 May 2022): a bilateral trade-agreement
- CAUTION: I2U2 (India-Israel-UAE-US): a minilateral framework on food security,

STATUS, DATE AND FIGURE LIMIT

- IMEC/IMEEC: an eight-party MoU signed on 9 September 2023 (India, US,
- Chabahar port (Iran): 10-year contract signed 13 May 2024; US sanctions
- Direct PYQ boundary case (2025 Q19): the question's framing — energy
- CAUTION: Boundary case — Iran under sanctions pressure: Tharoor notes "Iran's

COMPARATIVE DIPLOMATIC NUANCE

- CAUTION: Boundary case — Israel-Palestine escalation risk: any escalation
- CAUTION: Boundary case — diaspora welfare during regional conflict: any Gulf/
- CAUTION: Diversification manages risk but does not eliminate dependence: equity
- CAUTION: Triangular balancing requires continuous diplomatic management: the

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.

END OF MASTER CANVAS • poster embeds this exact master • tiled pages are overlapping crops of the same pixels